also recommended ideas that the Eisenhower administration had tried to implement. These included long-term assistance packages and burden sharing with allies. Kennedy's message to Congress in March argued that his aid policy was not designed just to contain communism but to assist positively in a "historical demonstration that … economic growth and political democracy go hand in hand."[159]

In an administration full of optimism, hope about democratic India facilitated the case for aiding that country in particular. Kennedy was impressed with its progress.[160] He wrote to Nehru that he would try to make the foreign assistance program more flexible and long term.[161] There was also optimism about the bilateral relationship, with even the US ambassador to Pakistan noting the "present excellent trend in Indo-American relations."[162] When taking on congressional contentions that the US was losing ground internationally, Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara cited India as one of the "bright spots" which proved that criticism wrong.[163]

Indian officials were reassured by the administration's attitude, even as they were concerned about the impact of American financial strain on its aid program. Senior American policymakers, who were reevaluating aid policy, clearly had "good intentions." Indian embassy officials knew, however, that implementation would depend on Congress.[164]

On Capitol Hill, advocates of aid for India highlighted the positive. They argued that even if India was lagging behind China somewhat in terms of growth rate, it was fighting the good fight for freedom. State Department officials pushed back against criticisms that US aid to India had not produced results and only strengthened government control of the economy. Advocates reiterating the "bases for optimism" argued that India continued to be "critically important." It was one of the "points of strength" in the underdeveloped world and in an "intense competition with the Communist system in China for recognized achievement." Moreover, India's agreement with Pakistan on the Indus Waters Treaty showed that it was willing to do whatever it took to keep its focus on development and China.[165]

As expected in the US and India, Congress rejected the administration's multiyear funding request, but India did not do badly. Of its total $900 million development assistance request for FY1962, the administration had proposed $500 million for India. Congress approved $465.5 million—more than double the amount in the previous year. India had estimated that it